



Xbox 360 Messenger Kit

Text and voice chat just got easier!

Console gamers need not worry about being deprived of keyboards anymore—well, not Xbox 360 owners, at least. Microsoft has thought it all out and designed a keyboard that works with the Xbox 360.

The keyboard—which is rather pretty—easily attaches to the bottom of the controller. It has a grey colour theme highlighted with white, orange, and green characters to denote special characters and punctuation marks, which can be accessed using the two (orange and green) function keys at the bottom. Unlike the [Shift] and [Alt] keys on a PC keyboard, these are toggle keys and don't require you to keep them held down. The keys are sturdy and give good feedback, much like those of good cell

phones. They are also backlit, which adds to the visual appeal—more importantly, this allows you to chat with the lights out.

Completing the kit is the headset (with only a single headphone). The headband is adjustable, but the length of the microphone's band isn't. It's flexible and you can change its direction, though. Comfort level is decent, and the set should fit most people. There's a small dial and switch for switching the microphone on and off, and for the headset volume.

RATINGS

Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★



The headset connects to the keyboard using a 2.5 mm connector for voice chat on Xbox Live. Don't expect to use this for in-game sound, though.

The Xbox 360 Messenger Kit is priced at Rs 1,600, and we think it's worth it. It brings a whole lot of flexibility to the console without being too

bulky, and blends in perfectly with the controller's shape. And chatting on Xbox Live will never be a pain again!

Contact: Redington
Phone: 1800-425-3718
E-mail: vivekul@microsoft.com
Web site: www.microsoft.com
Price: Rs 1,600

MSI NX8600GT T2D256E OC Edition

Overclocked, but not overpriced

The MSI NX8600GT follows MSI tradition with a fiery-red PCB. The single-slot cooling solution looks a little flimsy, but does the job well. The memory slots aren't cooled, but we didn't see that as an issue. The cooling solution itself is pleasing enough. MSI hasn't used an all solid-state capacitor design here.

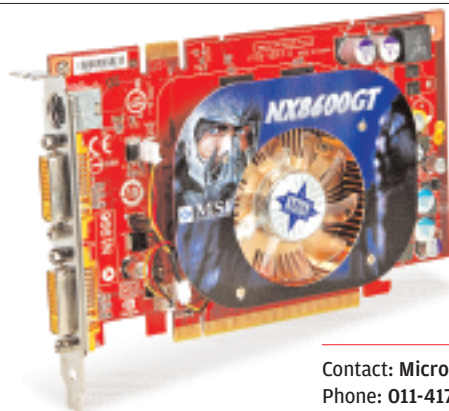
This version is overclocked; with a core speed of 580 MHz, it isn't the highest overclocked

8600GT part we've seen, though. Of course, the credit goes to NVIDIA for creating such an overclockable core, but we've seen the ASUS EN 8600GT at a core speed of 650 MHz. MSI clocks memory at 1600 MHz, and the shaders themselves run at just over 1.5 GHz.

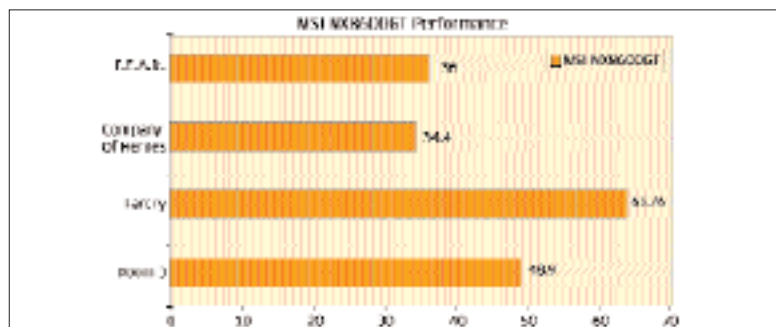
This one from MSI is a very good, slightly cheaper alternative to our mid-range gold winner this year—the ASUS EN8600GT.

Specifications

Core speed 580 MHz; Memory speed 1600 MHz; Shader Clocks: 1508 MHz



Contact: Micro-Star International
Phone: 011-41758808
Web site: www.msi-india.com
Price: Rs 7,500



RATINGS

Feature	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Bundle	★★★★★
Value for money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

XFX PV-T88P-YDD4

A (Ge)Force to be reckoned with

The new 8800 GT core is a fire-breather of a GPU based around a 65nm process. A significant change in this chipset (codenamed G92) is the new video processing engine, which should do wonders for hardware HD video decoding.

XFX's PV-T88P-YDD4 is based around an overclocked (670 vs 600 MHz) 8800GT core and is pegged their "Alpha Dog Edition," following the fraternity of vendors who like to name their top-end parts. The cooling solution is stock, with a funky-looking XFX sticker. A single-slot cooling solution for such a powerful card seemed like a recipe for fried GPU—and we did

notice temperatures close to an 8800GTX; not good.

Not only did the overclocked XFX PV-T88P-YDD4 come really close to the Manli 8800GTX card (which runs at stock speed), it actually defeats the mighty G80 core in two benchmarks (check the table)! In 3D Mark 2006, we figure this is due to the higher shader clock

Specifications	8800GTX	8800GTS	8800GT	8600GTS
Stream Processors	128	96	112	32
ROP	24	20	16	8
Core Speed	575	500	600	675
Memory Speed	1.8 GHz	1.6 GHz	1.8 GHz	2.0 GHz
Memory Bus Width	384-bit	320-bit	256-bit	128-bit

speed—3D Mark benchmarks are typically shader-heavy. *Company of Heroes* is (surprise!) another shader-intensive game—another triumph for

Contact: Rashi Peripherals Pvt Ltd
Phone: 022-67090909
Web site: www.rptechindia.com
Price: Rs 19,500

Manli 8800GTX

Do you really want it?

Another 8800GTX, different vendor. Manli is somewhat of a new entity in Indian markets, and this is the first graphics card from the Hong Kong-based firm that we're testing. The Manli 8800GTX looks identical to a stock 8800GTX.

Manli provides a very skimpy bundle with this card, and apart from the usual connectors, all we got was a driver CD. This, we assume, is just in order to keep the price down.

The Manli 8800GTX is no worse than other 8800GTXs we've tested. However, our demeanour has changed towards the

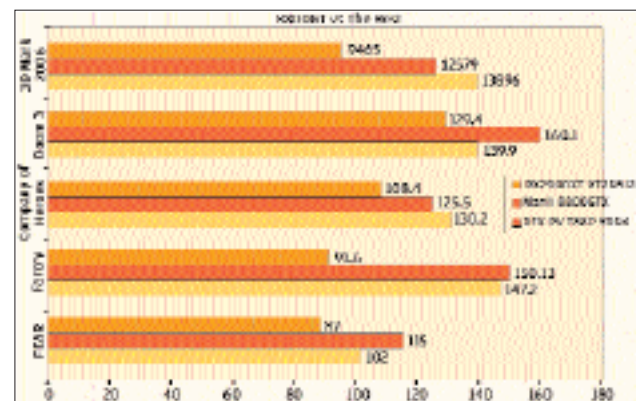
8800GTX. And with the aggressive pricing on the XFX PV-T88P-YDD4, other manufacturers won't be too far behind with equally competitive prices. At the current pricing, you could get two 8800GT cards (read SLI) for the price of a single 8800GTX, and their performance would—quite obviously—blow a single 8800GTX card out of the water.

RATINGS

Feature	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★



the XFX PV-T88P-YDD4. We expect stock 8800GT cards to be a bit slower than this card, but the biggest shocker of all is its price. Rs 19,500 is nearly half the price of an 8800GTX GPU based card—unbelievable!



Now isn't the time to be buying an 8800GTX card, unless you want the fastest and the best and are willing to pay the premium.

Contact: Shree Semiconductors
Phone: 022-23800951
Web site: www.shreesemi.com
Price: Rs 29,500